

THEATRE

Notable Faculty & Student Achievements

February 2026

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** designed the costumes and masks for Zach Theater's beloved classic, *Charlotte's Web*. This family-friendly production tells the story using live bluegrass music, aerial silk acrobatics, and mask work. Performances run through May 17. Get your tickets [here](#)!

January 2026

Professor of Theatre **Sergio Costola** recently published an article titled "Farò raddoppiare li segni pubblici de gaudio et letitia per la terra et per tutto. Lucrezia Borgia and Her Theatre of Diplomacy (1509–1512)" in *Storie e Linguaggi* 11.2 (2025). The article examines Lucrezia Borgia's diplomatic activity during the wars of the early sixteenth century, showing how the courtly receptions, musical performances, dances, and fashion spectacles she organized in Ferrara functioned not merely as displays of power but as active instruments of political negotiation and mediation. The article is available open access [here](#).

November 2025

Computer science and theatre double major **Aidan Balakrishnan** '26, computer science and mathematics double major **Tanner Klein** '26, and computer science major **Matthew Volkin** '26 participated in the Association of Computing Machinery's South Central USA Regional Programming Contest on November 8, solving seven out of 13 problems. Their team, the pi-rates, placed 4th among the 20 teams in the South Central USA Division. They participated in the competition at the University of Texas at Austin site, but were in competition with teams at other sites throughout the South Central USA Region. Teams in the Mid-Atlantic USA Region and Southeast USA Region competed on the same day, and across the entire conference, the pi-rates placed 17th out of 94 teams. The team was coached by Associate Professor of Computer Science **Jacob Schrum**.

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** designed the costumes for *A Charlie Brown Christmas* at Zach Theater in downtown Austin. This musical is based upon the classic Peanuts family favorite and is a wonderful holiday event for the whole family. The production runs from November 7 through the end of the year. Tickets can be obtained [here](#).

Theatre alumna **Olivia Rose McCain** '22 was awarded a 2025 B. Iden Payne Award for Outstanding Hair and Makeup Design for her work on *MotherTree* at the VORTEX Repertory in Austin. Olivia is an actor, designer, and entrepreneur with a successful podcast called *Gals & Goblins*.

July 2025

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed stage scenery and is the scenic charge artist for Magnolia Musical Theatre's production of *SpongeBob the Musical*. This professional production is directed by Professor Emeritus of Theatre **Rick Roemer**, with technical direction by Scene Shop Manager **Monroe Oxley**. Students **Ansh Tripathi** '28 and **Yeva Tcharikova** '28 collaborated with Roybal and Oxley as academic interns in the fabrication and painting of scenery. Students **Emma Hoover** '27, **Olivia Hynes** '27, **Piper Swisher** '27, and **Emily Williams** '28 are scenic carpenters and painters. The production is running Wednesday, Thursday, Friday, and Saturday evenings at 8:00 p.m. from July 16 through August 16 at the Hill Country Galleria Pavilion in Bee Cave, TX. Attendees are encouraged to bring a blanket or lawn chair and their favorite beverage to be transported to Bikini Bottom for an unforgettable evening of entertainment featuring a talented cast and crew performing alongside a live orchestra.

June 2025

Theatre alumnus **Kyle Bussone Peterson** '24 is currently appearing as "Motel Kamzoil" in *Fiddler on the Roof*, now playing on the historic Angus Springer Stage at the Palace Theatre. Motel is a sweet and timid character who stands up for himself when he and Tevye's daughter, Tzeitel announce their engagement. The production is directed by Professor Emeritus **Rick Roemer**, former Artistic Director and Chair of the Theatre Department. The show opened on May 30 and

February 2025

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** was invited to collaborate with the Drama Department at Austin Community College (ACC) on their production of *The Long Christmas Ride Home* by award-winning playwright Paula Vogel. Bechtel designed the costumes and mentored three ACC students in costumes, hair, makeup, and puppetry. This deeply moving play chronicles a seminal event in the life of Vogel and her siblings and features bunraku puppetry. The production runs through March 2, 2025. Tickets can be reserved [here](#).

Assistant Professor of Theatre **Gabriel Peña**, Scene Shop Supervisor **Monroe Oxley**, and Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** collaborated on Adam Gwan's chamber musical, *Ordinary Days*, for Penfold Theatre. This intimate musical follows four individuals as they navigate the frantic energy of New York City. Audiences are invited to consider the beauty of the ordinary as the characters connect, fall apart, lose each other, and find themselves. Peña served as director, Oxley as technical director, and Roybal as scenic designer. SU theatre major **Bethani Pedraza** '25 and theatre minor **Yeva Tcharikova** '28 provided technical assistance. Penfold Theatre is a 501(c)(3) professional theatre company recently setting roots in Round Rock, TX after 15 years of producing theatre in the greater Austin area. The productions run February 7 – March 1 at their new permanent home in Round Rock. The trailer, tickets, and information about Penfold Theatre is available [here](#).

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** designed the costumes for Unity Theatre's production of *The Trip to Bountiful*. This mid-20th century play was written by Pulitzer Prize-winning Texas native Horton Foote and explores themes of longing, discontent, and family. This production runs from February 6 through February 23 in historic Brenham, Texas. Tickets can be purchased at unitybrenham.org.

January 2025

Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy King** choreographed *The Secret Garden* at The Georgetown Palace Theatre. The musical, based on the children's novel, opens this Friday, January 31, and runs until Sunday, March 2. It plays Fridays and Saturdays at 7:30 p.m. and Sundays at 2:00 p.m. Tickets can be purchased [here](#).

October 2024

On October 15, Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy Rebecca King** spoke at the book launch for *Critical Acting Pedagogies: Intersectional Approaches*. The book launch was held at RADA (The Royal Academy of Dramatic Art) in London and online, broadcast in America and the

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed the scenery and stage properties for *I'm Proud of You* by Tim Madigan. This production is a staged adaptation of Madigan's novel, *I'm Proud of You: My Friendship with Fred Rogers*. The play chronicles the true and extraordinary bond between Tim Madigan, a Texas author and reporter for the Fort Worth Star-Telegram, and Fred Rogers, the iconic TV host of *Mister Rogers' Neighborhood*. This production will be the inaugural production in Penfold Theatre's new and permanent theatre venue in Round Rock, TX. Roybal also served as a theatre consultant on the new venue, which will be the first professional theatre in Round Rock. The production showcases Professor Emeritus **Rick Roemer** and SU alumnus **Zac Carr** '11 as actors. SU Scene Shop Manager **Monroe Oxley** is the Technical Director for this production. Additionally, the stage and seating risers were designed and constructed by Oxley using a build crew that included **Connor Bustos** '26 and **Ash Zunker** '25. The production runs October 4-26.

September 2024

Art history and theatre graduate **Gabriella Gonzalez Biziou** '12 starred in and associated-produced a beautifully executed short film titled *Foolhardy Love*. Gabriella is returning to Texas this month to promote the film, which follows a couple confronted with two very different desires for their future. An official selection for the Beverly Hills Film Festival 2024, *Foolhardy Lovescreens* in Austin at the Austin Under the Stars Film Festival on Thursday, September 12 at 7:30 p.m., and at the Austin Spotlight Film Festival on Saturday, September 14 at 7:00 p.m. The film has been nominated for Best Narrative (at both festivals), Best Director, Best Actress (at both festivals), and Best Actor. The trailer can be viewed [here](#).

August 2024

Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy Rebecca King**, along with her colleague Robert Torigoe, published a chapter entitled "Liberating Casting and Training Practices for Mixed-Asian Students" in *Critical Acting Pedagogy: Intersectional Approaches*. The chapter, which examines the history of multiracial representation and offers practical inclusive pedagogical approaches, can be found [here](#).

July 2024

This summer, Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy King** directed *Cats* at the Georgetown Palace Theatre. Recommended by SU's *Ride the Cyclone* director Kristen Rogers, King collaborated with Evelyn Hoelscher of the Spaces of Fontana Dance Company and music director Michael Rosensteel on a contemporary take on the classic production. The production runs Fridays and Saturdays at 7:30 p.m., and Sundays at 2:00 p.m. from August 2 through September 8. Tickets can be purchased [here](#).

CHANCE NOTES ON PERFORMANCE DOCUMENTATION. In *Scene: Journal of Theatre and Drama Studies*, 10.1 (2024): 61-80, Memory and Performance, Classical Reception in Early Modern Festivals. The Monographic Section was edited by Francesca Bortoletti, Giovanna Di Martino, and Eugenio Refini. The essay can be read [here](#).

June 2024

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** served as a theatre staging and venue consultant for Penfold Theatre's new home in Round Rock, TX. This is the first professional theatre venue in Round Rock. Penfold Theatre will open its 17th season and continues its mission of telling intimate stories of empathy and hope, curating performances by premier local artists, and nurturing theatremakers of today and tomorrow. The opening of this facility will also provide other performing artists access to affordable space at a time when venues are disappearing.

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed scenery and is the scenic charge artist for Magnolia Musical Theatre's production of *Footloose* the musical, running July 10 through August 10 at Hill Country Galleria Pavilion in Bee Cave, TX. This professional production is directed by Professor Emeritus of Theatre **Rick Roemer**, with technical direction by Scene Shop Manager **Monroe Oxley**. Students **Connor Bustos** '26 and **Em Hoover** '27 collaborated with Roybal and Oxley as academic interns in scenic fabrication and scenic art. Alumni **Kyle Bussone-Peterson** '24 and **Alex Cannata** '24, along with students **Ashlyn Zunker** '25 and **Olivia Hynes** '27 are scenic carpenters and painters.

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** designed the costumes for *The Star Spangled Girl* at Unity Theater in Brenham, TX. This classic Neil Simon comedy required 15 distinct costumes from the late 1960s for the three main characters. Unity Theater is a professional theatre company located in beautiful Washington County, attracting theatre artists and patrons from both the Austin and Houston areas. *The Star Spangled Girl* runs through June 30.

Professor of Theatre **Sergio Costola** was the keynote speaker for the International Conference "RAPPRESENTARE GLI ESTE. La comunicazione del potere Estense entro e oltre i confini della signoria" in Ferrara, Italy from May 23-25.

April 2024

Senior Research and Instruction Librarian **Katherine Hooker** presented a poster at the Texas Library Association's annual conference on April 17. "Three Ring Library Circus (But in a Good Way): Leaning into the Theme with Creative Instruction for Creative Students" summarized three-part library instruction delivered to students in Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel's** "Design Fundamentals" course. Students learned via an online escape game, a collaborative Padlet, and an InfoGuide, all highly customized around the course's vibrant circus theme.

March 2024

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** worked as a costume buyer for Amazon Pictures' new series "Fallout." Alumnus **Jonathan Knipscher** '03 was the Associate Costume Designer on the project. The show premieres on April 11, 2024. The series trailer can be seen [here](#).

Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy King** wrote, directed, and produced a staged reading of her new play *Finger Lickin' Good* at the Jones Theatre in February. The cast included students **Jason Bui** '27 as Raymond, **Kyle Bussone-Peterson** '24 as Kevin, and **Connor Bustos** '26 on stage directions. They were joined by guest Gina Houston in the leading role of Alice and Director of Business Internships and Assistant Professor of Business **Andy Ross** as Jim, etc., in his acting debut! The reading was also performed at Austin Community College in Highland Park.

February 2024

November 2023

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed the staging and was a scenic artist of scenery and stage properties for Penfold Theatre's production of Yasmina Reza's play, *Art*. The comedy is playing at the Ground Floor Theatre in Austin, TX. from Nov. 2 through Nov. 18. Glenda Wolfe, SU Costume Shop Manager, designed costumes, and the production was directed by Stephen Pounders, Professor of Theatre at Baylor University. The production explores the meaning of art and the meaning of friendship. When Serge purchases an all-white painting for \$200,000.00, his longtime friendship with good friends Marc and Yvonne is tested. Arguments quickly go from theoretical to personal to confrontational, and friendships hang in the balance. Yasmina Reza's sometimes heartbreaking play asks poignant questions about the meaning of art and friendship. The play has won the Moliere Awards for Best Play, Best Author, Best Production, the Lawrence Olivier Award for Best Comedy, and the Tony Award for Best Play. Penfold website: <https://tinyurl.com/art-penfold> Production stills: <https://tinyurl.com/ytafq9dr> Trailer: <https://youtu.be/7Mn5xqSNMK8>.

August 2023

In June, Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy King** completed the teacher certification program at The Meisner Institute and is now a Designated Meisner Teacher (DMT). King also led

panels by several theatre scholars from around the world.

Associate Professor and Chair of the Theatre Department **Kerry Bechtel** has accepted an invitation to serve on The United States Institute of Theatre Technology (USITT) Costume Commission Leadership Board and as the International Organization of Scenographers, Theatre Architects and Technicians (OISTAT) representative for a three-year term. OISTAT organizes the Prague Quadrennial and World Stage Design Event and is a collective of theatre creatives working worldwide. The USITT Costume Commission develops and oversees national and regional programming and events for professionals, academics, and students involved in the fields of design and technical theatre.

On August 3rd, **Gabriel Peña** presented at the American Theatre in Higher Education conference. He spoke on the panel "Spotlight on New Works LIA (Latinx Indigenous and the Americas) and ATDS (American Theatre and Drama Society). Only two books were selected by LIA to highlight this year, and he presented on behalf of one of them, Marissa Chibás' work "Mythic Imagination and the Actor: Exercises, Inspiration, and Guidance for the 21 Century Actor".

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed scenery and was Scenic Charge Artist for Magnolia Musical Theatre's inaugural production of the musical, "Beauty and the Beast," running July 19 through August 13 at the Galleria Pavillion in Bee Cave, TX. This professional production is directed by SU theatre faculty Emeritus, Rick Roemer, with technical direction by SU theatre scene shop manager, Monroe Oxley. Bella Morrow '25 and Piper Swisher '26 collaborated with Roybal as academic interns in scenic fabrication and scenic art. Kyle Bussone-Peterson '24, Alex Canatta '24, and Ashlyn Zunker '25 were scenic carpenters.

Professor of Theatre and Dean of the Faculty **Sergio Costola**, JaimeLynn Hotaling '23, and Maisie Jones '23 presented a paper titled "Undergraduate Research and Theatre: Lessons Learned during the Pandemic" at the 2023 ConnectUR Annual Conference, held June 26-28 at Duquesne University in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania.

June 2023

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed and painted scenery for Penfold Theatre's world premiere production of "Box," running June 23 through July 8 at the Ground Floor Theatre in Austin, TX. The playscript and production is a two-year collaboration with Jarrett King, playwright-in-residence at the Goodman Theatre in Chicago, IL; Ryan Crowder, Producing Artistic Director of Penfold Theatre; and a collaborative production team with direction from Simone Alexander, Producing Artistic Director and Founder of New Manifest Theatre Company, Austin, TX. SU

is a story about Mr. Henry "Box" Brown, an abolitionist born into slavery in 1815 and escaped slavery at 33 by arranging to have himself shipped via a wooden crate from Virginia to an abolitionist in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, in 1849. The crate measured 3'1" long x 2'6" high x 2' wide, equipped with 3 holes for air and a water bladder. The sealed crate was transported by wagon, railroad, steamboat, and ferry over an approximated time of 27 hours. Watch the trailer [here](#).

Associate Professor and Chair of the Department of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** completed the costume design for the mid-century classic musical *Godspell* by John-Michael Tebelak and Stephen Schwartz. This production runs through June 25, 2023, at Unity Theater, a professional AEA and USA-associated theater company in Brenham, Texas. <https://unitybrenham.org/>

April 2023

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** secured a design contract with Magnolia Musical Theatre to design the stage scenery for the musical *Beauty and the Beast*. The production is being directed by Southwestern University Professor Emeritus Rick Roemer, with Technical Direction by Monroe Oxley, Southwestern University Scene Shop Supervisor. The production will be presented at the Galleria at Bee Caves, TX. July 18-August 13.

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** secured a scenic design contract with Penfold Theatre. The project is threefold: 1. Collaboration with Chicago playwright Jarrett King to develop an original playscript about the life and times of Henry "Box" Brown. 2. Specifically, design and paint early 20th Century roll drop scenery with dry pigment paint and ground flake animal glue. 3. Present the design in a modern presentational format at the Ground Floor Theatre, Austin, TX, in June 2023. Henry "Box" Brown was an abolitionist who was born into slavery in 1815 and escaped slavery at the age of 33 by arranging to have himself shipped via a wooden crate from Virginia to an abolitionist in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, in 1849. Henry Brown went on to lecture for the abolitionist movement in New England before moving to England, where he continued to speak out about the evils of slavery and performed his one-man show, Henry Box Brown's Mirror of Slavery.

March 2023

Assistant Professor of Theatre **Gabriel Peña** presented a workshop at SETC (the Southeastern Theatre Conference) in Lexington, Kentucky, on March 3. His workshop "Sensing Possibilities: Feldenkrais Method and its Potential Applications for Performers" explored how Awareness Through Movement lessons, often utilized as physical therapy, can be resourceful to actors.

Professor of English **Michael Saenger** and Associate Professor of Theatre **Sergio Costola** collaborated on a book titled *Shakespeare in Succession: Translation and Time* (McGill-Queen's University Press, 2023). The edited collection brings together scholars from eight different countries and five continents.

January 2023

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed A Christmas Carol for Penfold Theatre, which was presented at Old Settlers Hall in Round Rock, Texas, December 8-23. The classic radio cast production involved the design of a 1930s radio broadcast venue where five female actors represented all characters while also hand-operating Foley sound effects. The production ran at Old Settlers Hall December 8-18 before moving to the Driskill Hotel in Austin for a two-night run December 22 and 23.

October 2022

Associate Professor of Theatre and Associate Dean of the Faculty **Sergio Costola** presented a paper titled "Lucrezia Borgia and Theatrical Practice of Women in Elite Society" at a conference on

Associate Professor of Theatre and Associate Dean of the Faculty **Sergio Costola** presented a paper titled “The Battle of Polesella (1509). Diplomatic Relations and the Performing Arts” at the 10th Splendid Encounters Conference, Beyond the Truth. Misinformation and Credibility in Early Modern Diplomacy (Florence, Italy, October 12-14, 2022).

September 2022

Visiting Assistant Professor of Theatre **Amy Rebecca King** organized a panel titled “Mixed-Asian Casting” for the 2022 Association for Theatre in Higher Education Annual Conference, held July 28–31 in Detroit, Michigan. Even though multicultural people make up the fastest-growing demographic in America, they are underrepresented in the media. This panel explored the issues that multicultural actors, specifically mixed-Asian actors, experience in the casting industry. King, along with her colleagues Reiko Aylesworth (Southern Methodist University) and Robert Torigoe (University of Hawaii), gathered interviews with actor Amy Hill, casting director Victor Vazquez, and editor-in-chief of Mixed Asian Media Alex Chester and explored the experiences of mixed-Asian actors, as well as the difficulties of casting according to race in film/TV, theatre, and media. The session was very well attended, and the first-time panelists have been invited back to present at next year’s conference.

June 2022

Associate Professor of Theatre and Department Chair **Kerry Bechtel** designed the costumes for a production of *The Sweet Delilah Swim Club* at Unity Theater in Brenham, Texas. Unity Theater is a professional theater located midway between Austin and Houston that brings together professional actors, directors, and designers from both cities. The production runs from June 2–19.

May 2022

Theatre students **Dane Parker** '22, **Campbell Duffy** '22, **Jaime Hotaling** '23, **Harrison Jones** '23, **Oskar Brian** '22, **Jessica Workman** '22, **Ash Zunker** '25, and **Lilly Percifield** '22 performed *G.H.O.S.T. Unit: The Live Event* on February 26 and advanced from the Region 6 Festival (where they received three Meritorious Achievement Awards for Innovative Theatre Practices, Outstanding Ensemble, and Support of New Work) to the national Kennedy Center American College Theater Festival. Cast and crew received the Innovative Theatrical Experience Special Achievement Award. *G.H.O.S.T. Unit: The Live Event* is part of Associate Professor of Theatre **Sergio Costola**'s 2021–2022 and 2022–2023 faculty-student projects.

education, training, and mentorship to aspiring BIPOC producers. She also was invited to participate in a “Women in Theatre” panel at Texas State University on April 30.

Feburary 2022

Associate Professor of Theatre and Paideia Director **Sergio Costola** and **Jaime Hotaling** '23 presented a paper titled “Theatre Education at the Crossroads: Lessons Learned during the Pandemic” at the 2022 American Association of Colleges and Universities (AAC&U) Conference on General Education, Pedagogy, and Assessment, held February 10–12 in San Diego, California.

December 2021

Professor of Theatre **Desiderio Roybal** designed a 1930s scenic setting of a fictional KPNF radio station for Penfold Theatre in Austin. The audience experiences the arrival of a small company of virtuosic voice actors who perform multiple roles in the radiocast of *A Miracle on 34th Street* using live Foley sound effects. The load-in and installation was assisted by Southwestern student **Dusty Cutler** '25. The production runs December 9–19.

Associate Professor of Theatre and Paideia Director **Sergio Costola** collaborated with Olly Crick on a book to be published by Routledge in December 2021. The book, titled *The Dramaturgy of Commedia dell'Arte*, examines commedia dell'arte as a performative genre and one that should be analyzed through the framework of dramaturgy and dramaturgical practice.

November 2021

Associate Professor of Theatre **Kerry Bechtel** was invited to review the recently published book *Shoe Reels: The History and Philosophy of Footwear in Film* for *The Journal of Dress History*, published by the Association of Dress Historians. The review appeared in the winter 2021 issue.

September 2021

Students **Dane Parker '22**, **Campbell Duffy '22**, **Jaime Hotaling '23**, **Harrison Jones '23**, **Oskar Brian '22**, and **Jessica Workman '22** performed *G.H.O.S.T. Unit: The Live Event* on September 29 for the two respondents of the Kennedy Center American College Theater Festival and received three Meritorious Achievements for Innovative Theatre Practices, Outstanding Ensemble, and Support of New Work. Hotaling and Duffy were also nominated for the prestigious Irene Ryan Acting Award. *G.H.O.S.T. Unit: The Live Event* was directed by part-time Assistant Professor of

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